

Q1. *Is there a page limit or recommended length for the SSN response?*

- A. Interested Parties in assisting NIEHS with this market research are requested to submit the following information in the format of a White Paper outlined below. The response should be concise (no more than 20 pages), 11 pt Calibri font, and address only the information requested below. Bulleted lists and summaries are acceptable. (Note: title pages, cover letters, etc., will not count against the total page limit). Responses are to be submitted electronically to: Lisa.schaupp@nih.gov and filardok@nih.gov.

Q2. *Section III.b references subparagraph iv; however, we were unable to locate subparagraph iv in the document. Could you please clarify if additional information is intended for this section?*

- A. This was an oversight and was corrected to read *i. through iii.*

Q3. *Does the Government anticipate a future solicitation for this effort to be structured as a single-award or multiple-award contract?*

- A. The current contract is a single award. At this time, the Government cannot state whether the follow on will be single or multiple award as this requirement is still in the market research phase.

Q4. *Given the efficiencies that will be gained from AI and large language models in systematic review, how does the Government intend to structure this procurement to benefit from these advances?*

- A. As described in the SOW (section 2.9) the resulting contract would have a Capability Area focused on the development of novel tools and informatics approaches for literature-based evaluations. These activities may include evaluating novel methods for AI-enabled literature screening, evaluating model-based or AI-assisted alternative data extraction techniques, or AI-assisted study quality/informativeness assessment tools. As these developed tools mature and are deemed appropriate for use, they would be implemented in other areas of the contract, particularly Capability Areas 2.2 (Systematic Evidence Mapping and Scoping Reviews of Environmental Health Literature) and 2.3 (Systematic Review and Evidence Synthesis). As outlined in Section 3 of the SOW, the proposed contract mechanism would allow each activity under the contract to follow a Research Outline that is prepared and issued by the Government. This workflow allows the Government to fully leverage developments in technology over time, such that the methodology used for a Systematic Review in year one of the contract may differ from those utilized in year ten, based on the availability of new technologies and as required by the Government in a specific Research Outline.

Q5. Are there any explicit expectations about traveling and giving updates in person? For example, for program management component – is program manager expected to appear at NIEHS in person, if so, how often?

- A. Explicit expectations for travel have not been determined at this time as this notice is to establish the capabilities of potential vendors only. More details will be posted in the solicitation notice on SAM.gov.

Q6. Will the criteria for the extensions (for years 2 -10) be explicitly published?

- A. Proposed contract structure will be posted with in the solicitation notice on SAM.gov. This notice is to establish the capabilities of potential vendors.

Q7. Any novel tools/algorithms/predictive/foundational models – what will be the license type attached to them, can the vendor retain the right to further commercialize these tools (assuming base code will be open access)?

- A. Clauses appropriate for Data Rights and IT security are customarily included in contract solicitations. Any future solicitation for this requirement will likely address this question. Questions can also be submitted to a solicitation if they do not specifically answer these questions. This notice is to establish the capabilities of potential vendors.

Q8. Where will the work be performed? Are remote arrangements acceptable?

- A. This is to be determined. This requirement is in the market research stage.

Q9. What are the anticipated key personnel positions?

- A. Please review the Statement of Work attached to the announcement for anticipated key personnel positions.

Q10. What is the anticipated timeline for issuing formal solicitation?

- A. The anticipated timeline is Fiscal Year 2026. This is subject to change.

Q11. What will be the primary evaluation factors in the upcoming solicitation?

- A. The factors for evaluation will be posted within the solicitation. This notice is to establish the capabilities of potential vendors and is for market research only.

Q12. Can you share information about the current contract value and performance period?

- A. The current contract number is 75N96025C00003. The total estimated cost-plus fixed fee is \$13,683,134. The anticipated performance period is May 29, 2027.

Q13. What is the anticipated period of performance?

- A. The Government anticipates an award in May 2027. This is subject to change.

Q14. Are teaming arrangements or joint ventures acceptable for responding to the potential solicitation?

- A. This requirement is in the market research stage.

Q.15. Expected yearly volume for systematic reviews and advisory meetings

- A. This is to be determined. This requirement is in the market research stage. Details will be posted in the solicitation.

Q.16 Confirm the place of performance and any geographical restrictions

- A. A place of performance cannot be determined at this time. This requirement is in the market research stage.

Q.17. Will contract staff be given government accounts or GFE (3.1, "The Contractor shall use a DTT program and project management (PPM) software (i.e., Microsoft Dynamics 365) specified by the Government to document and update research activities, including, but not limited to, research outlines submitted by the Government, technical work plans and budget information, milestone schedules, work status, interim data (in the form of tables, graphs, spreadsheets, and/or other documents), and deliverables. All substantive communication and decisions throughout the performance of work on an activity shall be documented within the software.")

- A. If contract staff will be given government accounts or GFE, this information will be provided within the solicitation. This requirement is in the market research stage.

*As stated in the announcement, THIS SSN DOES NOT CONSTITUTE A SOLICITATION (e.g., Invitation for Bids (IFB), Request for Proposal (RFP), Request for Quotation (RFQ), etc.) nor is it to be construed as a commitment by the Government. **The information requested may be used as market research for planning purposes and to facilitate decision making (i.e., acquisition strategy determinations, availability of capable small business concerns, etc.).***